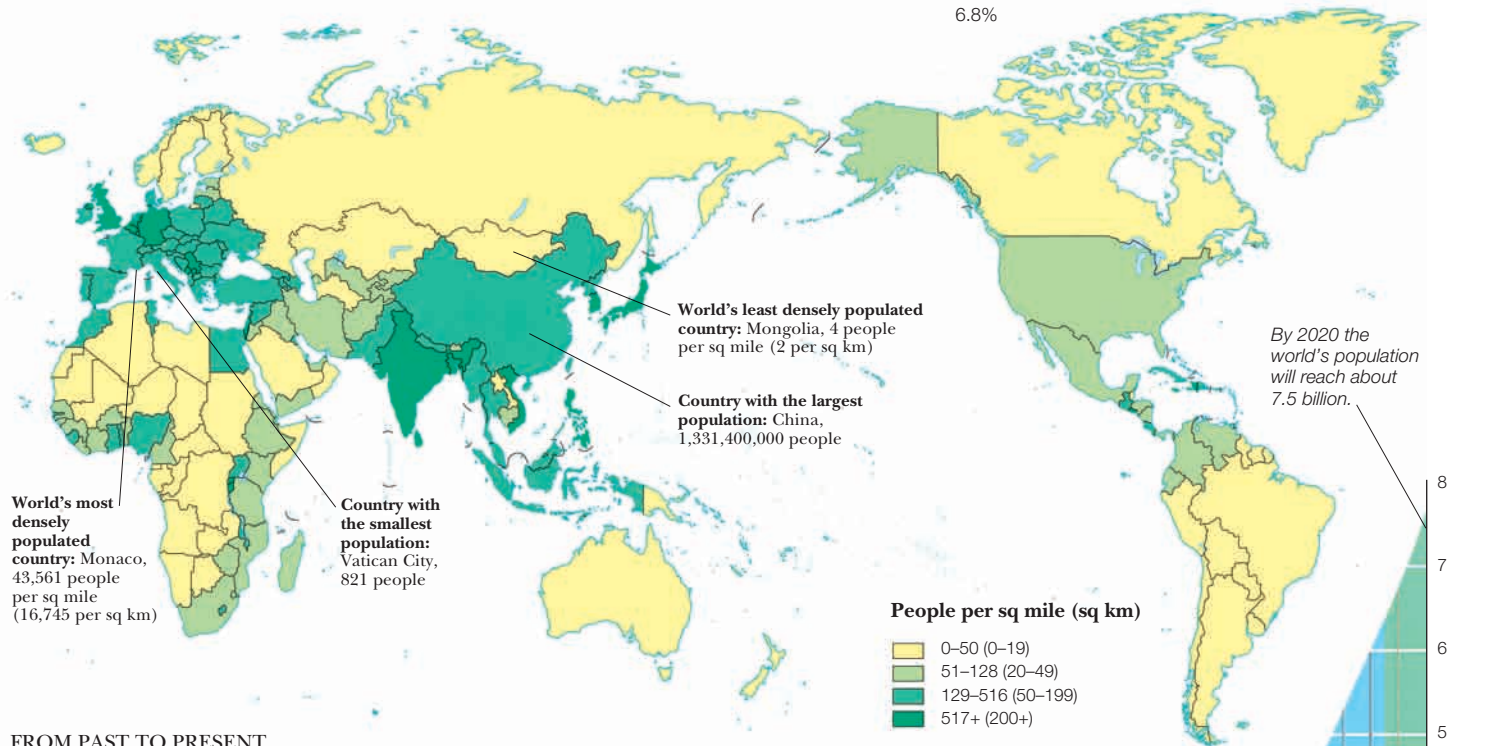


WORLD POPULATION

PEOPLE HAVE LIVED ON EARTH for at least 2 million years. For most of that time, population size remained steady, because the number of people born roughly equaled the number that died. Disease and famine ensured that the size of the population did not overtake supplies of food and other resources. However, as farming methods became more efficient and medical knowledge improved, population size rapidly began to increase. It now stands in excess of 6 billion people, with more than one million babies born every four days. In many parts of the world, rapid population growth has created serious problems, such as food shortages and overcrowding in cities.

World map showing the population density of each country



FROM PAST TO PRESENT

In 1500, the world's population stood at 425 million. The majority of these people were concentrated in towns and villages in the northern hemisphere. At first the growth rate was gradual, but from 1800 onward, better health care and food production, and the Industrial Revolution led to rapid world growth. Between 1950 and 1990 alone, the population doubled. Most of the population growth between now and 2020 is projected to occur in Africa, Asia, and Central and South America – the regions that are least able to afford such increases.

In 1500 the world's population was about 425 million.

In 1600 the world's population was about 545 million.

In 1700 the world's population was about 610 million.

In 1800 the world's population was about 900 million.

In 1900 the world's population was about 1.6 billion.

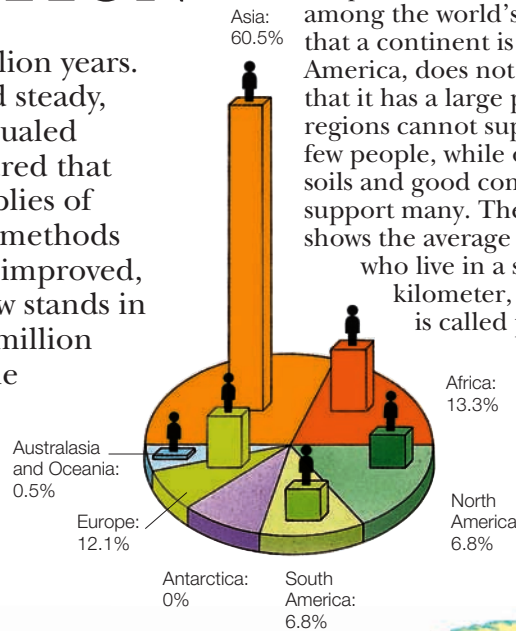
In 1950 the world's population was about 2.5 billion.

By 2020 the world's population will reach about 7.5 billion.



WHERE PEOPLE LIVE

People are not evenly distributed among the world's continents. The fact that a continent is large, such as North America, does not necessarily mean that it has a large population. Some regions cannot support more than a few people, while others, with fertile soils and good communications, can support many. The world map below shows the average number of people who live in a square mile, or kilometer, in each country. This is called population density.



This chart shows the size of each continent or region, together with the percentage of the world's population living on it. Far more people live in Asia than anywhere else on Earth.